

Figure 14: Robert Ashe (the garlanded white man with a moustache). To his right is N.A.V. Somasundaram Pillai, a director of SSNCo

Gauging that the vakils of Tuticorin were the backbone of SSNCo —'Respectable gentlemen working honorarily for the Swadeshi cause, much to the detriment of their professional work'[22]—and that VOC drew much of his strength from them, Ashe took action under the security sections of the Criminal Procedure Code against six leading lawyers, all ardent supporters of the SSNCo: K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar, P.L. Vengu Aiyar, K. Balaji Rao, Ramakrishna Iyer, Narayanaswamy Sastri and Gurunatha Aiyar. Striking at VOC's fervent backers, he was also issuing a warning to everyone. As 'Constable, Prosecutor and Judge' in the case, he harassed them and thereby obstructed the functioning of the Swadeshi company. He was so vindictive that the vakils, all men of standing, were not even given seats during the inquiry.[23]

A series of witnesses was called to testify that SSNCo, VOC and the accused vakils had intimidated BI's clientele. The crucial meeting on 29 February that VOC had with the residuary traders still shipping with BI—